The 2024 Floods of Bangladesh: A Story of Hope and Ham Radio

With rapidly rising waters in Feni knocking out most modes of communication and isolating those caught in the disaster, local operators got on the air to help.

Abdullah Al Fahad, S21AF

On August 20, 2024, the usual hum of life in Feni District, Bangladesh, was swallowed by a sudden deluge caused by heavy rainfall and runoff from the hills of Tripura, plunging the entire area into chaos. By nightfall, embankments in the Parshuram and Fulgazi *upazilas* (units in the administrative system of Bangladesh) broke, triggering severe flooding. The central and northern areas of Feni suffered the most.

On average, a major flood hits Feni every 8 to 10 years, while smaller floods occur almost annually. Although the people of Feni are familiar with floods, the 2024 flood was different, because the water flow was extremely rapid, and within just half an hour, many villages were already underwater — electricity, mobile networks, and food supply systems were disrupted almost instantly, isolating everyone caught in the disaster.

A Call for Help

Amid the turmoil, a call came over the radio from Dr. Asif Ud Doula, S21NWR, who became trapped by the encroaching waters. He shared that all his other forms of communication were cut off, and he needed help getting the word out about the floods. But the other amateur radio operators (who spontaneously responded during the flood) and I couldn't reach him immediately because the roads were gone and water kept rising; all we had at this time were our radios. So, while most of us were hundreds of kilometers (more than 130 miles) away from Dr. Asif in Dhaka, he kept us updated from Feni.



Team members coordinating rescue efforts from Kakrail Scout Headquarters.

A few of us who had received our amateur radio license began discussing the situation in a WhatsApp group. Under my coordination, along with Sabbir Hossain, S21ACP; Mob Jihad, S21MOB; Muhammed "Rifat" Muniruzzaman Dhali, S21AIG; Abu Noman Md. Shiful Islam "Sunny," S21TE, and S21NWR, we devised a plan to focus on helping Feni because it had suffered the most. We talked about who could go, what equipment we had, and what steps we needed to take.

Despite challenges — the limited number of radio devices allowed by the Bangladesh Telecommunication Regulatory Commission and the high cost of importing equipment — we pushed forward using our own funds and resources. We used portable antennas, handheld radios, *base radios* (two-way radios designed for a stationary location), and omni antennas for base stations. To ensure long-distance communication between Dhaka and Feni, we set up a Yagi antenna. We arranged our own transport to reach Feni (which included carrying our radio gear 12 kilometers, or about 7.5 miles, through the district while it was entirely underwater), and, as electricity and local markets were mostly unavailable, we also had to carry emergency food and water. This wasn't a matter of just helping S21NWR — this was about helping everyone caught in the flood.

Setting Up Emergency Communications

We finally reached Feni on the evening of August 22, approximately 48 hours after the flooding began. We established our first base station on the rooftop of Tara Nibash, a 15-story building, and set up a control room at the Feni Deputy Commissioner's office. At 9 PM that night, our first team — S21ACP, S21MOB, and S21AIG — arrived to help. Fahim, a trained volunteer who passed the Bangladesh Amateur Radio Service exam but was waiting to receive his call sign, took charge of coordinating with the Deputy Commissioner's office to make sure everything ran smoothly. By the next day, more operators had joined us, including S21TE; Mutammim Mahmud Asif, S21NN, and Dr. Deepta



Establishing a base station on the rooftop of Tara Nibash.

Majumder, S21HK, who brought along a team of medical students from the Platform Doctors Foundation (a voluntary group of Bangladeshi doctors and medical and dental students who work together to improve the health sector of Bangladesh). Together, we successfully extended our network farther, setting up more stations at the Mohipal Army Camp and a temporary army medical camp.

Two base areas were established: one at Kakrail Scout Headquarters (the national headquarters of Bangladesh Scouts) in Dhaka and another at my home in Demra Thana. I couldn't be at the Scout headquarters all the time, so having a station at home meant I could stay involved around the clock. However, it was only one-way communication, which meant the team in Feni could hear me, but I couldn't hear them. Thankfully, they managed to pick up my transmissions on the rooftop of Tara Nibash. To send updates back to me, S21ACP would walk up to the rooftop of Tara Nibash every evening (because that spot had some mobile signals) and inform me of the day's operations, rescues, and outcomes of my messages. I kept sending updates and information about people in need, and every bit of information I relayed helped the army and Deputy Commissioner's office direct their resources more effectively.

In the Field

As the flood raged on, our network became the lifeline for the entire region. The army's communications systems had been damaged by the flood, so they relied on us to keep in touch with their teams in the field. Every rescue boat deployed to the most distant and dangerous locations had one of our operators on board maintaining a constant line of communication with the Feni control room. We had to conserve power, so after establishing contact every 30 minutes, we'd switch off our devices to save battery life — but we never lost connection.

For the first 4 days, our team worked nonstop to coordinate rescue efforts and relay crucial information. This helped facilitate more than 375 rescue missions throughout some of the most remote and difficult-to-reach areas. Our amateur radio network was the only link between the different rescue units and the control room within a 70-kilometer (43.5-mile) radius. This effort was led by a community of people — Scout members, Red Crescent (**www.ifrc.org**) volunteers, doctors, engineers, and university students from all over the country. Many of us were connected through informal communities on social media.

By August 27, nearly 1 week after the flooding began, the water finally began to recede and rescue operations became more effective.

Looking Ahead

After learning from this experience, the Bangladesh DX Club (**https://bdxc.org**) decided to form a team dedicated to emergency communications. While it's still in the works, the plan is to define emergency frequencies, prepare trained field operators, and build readiness for any future disaster.

All photos provided by the author.

Abdullah Al Fahad, S21AF, has been a licensed ham since 2016. He is the secretary of the Bangladesh DX Club and co-founder and managing director of Onirban Electronics & Engineering, which builds radio communication equipment under the brand TORUN. It's the first of its kind in Bangladesh and specializes in walkie-talkies, mobile radios, and HF radios for commercial and amateur use. Abdullah enjoys operating HF with his Icom IC-706MKII, an sBitx, and a variety of homebrew antennas. Passionate about FT8, he also enjoys SSB and is active on DMR Talkgroups 91 and 470. Abdullah can be reached at **fahadmieaji@gmail.com**.

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